10.4.1 Identifying the hosting environment

When you create a `WebApplicationBuilder` instance in Program.cs, it automatically sets up the hosting environment for your application. By default, `WebApplicationBuilder` uses, perhaps unsurprisingly, an environment variable to identify the current environment. The `WebApplicationBuilder` looks for a magic environment variable called `ASPNETCORE_ENVIRONMENT`, uses it to create an `IHostEnvironment` object, and exposes it as `WebApplicationBuilder.Environment`.

NOTE You can use either the `DOTNET_ENVIRONMENT` or `ASPNETCORE_ENVIRONMENT` environment variable. The `ASPNETCORE_` value overrides the `DOTNET_` value if both are set. I use the `ASPNETCORE_` version throughout this book.

The `IHostEnvironment` interface exposes several useful properties about the running context of your app. The `ContentRootPath` property, for example, tells the application in which directory it can find any configuration files, such as appsettings.json. This folder is typically the one in which the application is running.

TIP `ContentRootPath` is *not* where you store static files that the browser can access directly; that's the `WebRootPath`, typically wwwroot. `WebRootPath` is also exposed on the `Environment` property via the `IWebHostEnvironment` interface.

The `IHostEnvironment.EnvironmentName` property is what interests us in this section. It's set to the value of the `ASPNETCORE_ENVIRONMENT` environment variable, so it can be any value, but you should stick to three commonly used values in most cases: